

NOTE OF WARNING MLA and former tribal minister Govinda Gawade speaks at a UTAA meeting, Jul. 30

KAILAS NAIK

▶ GOA

TRIBAL CLOCK TICKING

The Adivasis get the political quota they wanted, but implementation will be tricky

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

GOA IS RACING TOWARDS VOTING SEASON but a key element in its electoral architecture is in flux. Assembly polls are due by early 2027, but the Pramod Sawant government, which was facing a minefield over the delayed granting of political reservations to the state's Scheduled Tribes (STs), may have got a reprieve. In August 2025, Parliament had approved a bill to grant a 10 per cent electoral quota to tribals in Goa—in line with their 10.23 per cent share in the population. That would have translated into four ST-reserved seats, a crucial bloc in a 40-member assembly historically fraught by razor-thin majorities. The Centre has notified the act (it came into force on August 6), but it will be a big ask to ensure the seats with the most ST population gets reserved status in time for the polls, considering the statutory procedures.

The state presently has four tribal MLAs, elected from general seats. Three are from the BJP, including speaker Ganesh Gaonkar, minister Ramesh Tawadkar and ex-minister Govind Gaude. The Scheduled Castes (SCs) have one reserved seat: Pernem, in North Goa. STs and SCs also have 12.5 per cent and 2 per cent reservations respectively in jobs and education.

Earlier, the United Tribals Associations Alliance (UTAA) had threatened to hit the streets with an Adivasi mahasabha at Panaji on August 13. UTAA president and ex-MLA Prakash Velip had been on an outreach in the state's 750-odd tribal hamlets, saying, "Tribals have been unable to get quota benefits in four elections (since 2007)."

Takeaways

- **Tribal body gets their demand, four reserved seats**
- **10% of population, they can swing many assembly seats**
- **Other sections unhappy, move may backfire on BJP**

Political quotas are an emotional issue for Goa's tribals. In May 2011, a UTAA protest at Balli had taken a violent turn and led to the death of two tribal youth, and cost the Congress, then in the government. A big chunk of tribal votes went to the BJP in the 2012 election, and it has held on to power ever since. Now, facing anti-incumbency after three straight terms, it, too, confronts a complex set of equations.

The ruling BJP faces a number of impediments in ensuring the ST quotas are implemented. For one, the grapevine suggests the election may be pre-poned to year-end, so the four seats must be reserved before this. Meanwhile, other communities like sections of the Bhandaris and Kshatriya Marathas are opposed to these political quotas in their present form as most